NOTRUMP OPENINGS

These 100 Deals are all about hands that are either opened 1NT or 2NT, or perhaps overcalled 1NT or 2NT. Some of them end up being played at a Notrump contract, but others are played with a trump suit.

The proficiency level for the Deals is Intermediate/Advanced, both in the Bidding and Declarer play.

ABOUT THE DEALS

With both hands visible and the opening lead noted you are asked to make a Plan for each Deal. You should think this through just as if you were at the table.

All of the Notrump Plans include a Winner Count and all Suit Plans include a Loser Count.

During the Bidding section you are in the South position. As a result of that some of the Deals would end up with your partner North as the Declarer.

ABOUT THE BIDDING

Normal 4-3-2-1 point count is used, with 1 length point added for any card more than 4 in any suit.
1NT Opening: 15-17 points
2NT Opening: 20-21 points
1NT Overcall: 15-18 points, at least 1, (preferably 2), stoppers in their suit
2NT Overcall over a Weak 2-bid: 15-18 points, at least 1, (preferably 2), stoppers

Stayman convention is used extensively.

Jacoby Transfers are used extensively.
In addition to the standard 2♦ transfer to ♥ and 2♥ transfer to ♠ we also use a 2♠ transfer to 3♣.

The **lebensohl** convention is used when opponents overcall your side's 1NT opening.
Since this is not a standard for many of you, a brief explanation/comment is given when it occurs.

You can go either go through the deals in order, or use the Navigation Bar at left.

Board: 1
Dealer: **North**

Contract: 3NT
Declarer: North
Lead: ♥J

Board: 2
Dealer: **East**

Contract: 3NT
Declarer: East
Lead: ♠4

Board: 3
Dealer: **South**

Contract: 3NT
Declarer: South
Lead: ♠6

Board: 4
Dealer: **East**

Contract: 4♠
Declarer: West
Lead: ♥5

Board: 5
Dealer: **North**

Contract: 3NT
Declarer: North
Lead: ♥Q

Board: 6
Dealer: **East**

Contract: 3NT
Declarer: East
Lead: ♠3

Board 1
North Deals
None Vul

	♠ A Q J 10 ♥ A 6 5 ♦ A Q 8 5 ♣ K 10	
♠ K 8 6 4 ♥ K 7 4 ♦ 10 7 3 ♣ Q J 3		♠ 9 2 ♥ J 10 9 8 2 ♦ 9 4 ♣ A 9 7 6
	♠ 7 5 3 ♥ Q 3 ♦ K J 6 2 ♣ 8 5 4 2	

West	*North*	*East*	*South*
	2NT	Pass	3NT
All Pass			

3NT by North
Lead: ♥J

With 20 HCP and balanced distribution you should open 2NT. Do not let the good 4-card ♠ suit sway you to anything else. Partner bids 3NT and everybody passes.

North plays 3NT. East leads the ♥J. You try the ♥Q, but West plays the ♥K.

Winner List: ♠ = 1 : ♥ = 0 : ♦ = 4 : ♣ = 1 :: Total = 6

You need 3 more winners and at least 2 of them must come from ♠s. Furthermore you don't want West to lead ♣s through your King. Your best hope is that West holds the ♠K so you can finesse.

So you win the ♥A and start thinking about dummy entries. Your obvious entries are the ♦K and ♦J. If West holds only two small ♠s with his ♠K, then two entries will be enough. But what if West holds ♠ K x x x ? Can you find a third entry to dummy?

If the ♦s split 3-2 the answer is **YES**. Play the ♦A, then lead your ♦8 to dummy's ♦J. Watch carefully to see if both defenders follow to this trick. They do. Play a ♠ to your ♠10, which holds the trick. Play your ♦Q to dummy's ♦K. Finesse the ♠ again. Return to dummy by playing your ♦5 to dummy's ♦6, then finesse the ♠ one last time.

If the ♦s had split 4-1 you would not have been able to enter dummy three times. That would have been very unlucky.

If you played your ♦5 too early you would not have been able to enter dummy three times even when there was a 3-2 split. That would have been very unsmart.

Board 2
East Deals
N-S Vul

	♠ 7 6 ♥ K 10 7 ♦ Q J 6 2 ♣ Q 7 6 2	
♠ K J 3 ♥ J 8 3 ♦ 7 4 ♣ J 10 9 5 4	N W E S	♠ A Q 9 ♥ A 6 4 2 ♦ A 10 9 3 ♣ A K
	♠ 10 8 5 4 2 ♥ Q 9 5 ♦ K 8 5 ♣ 8 3	

West	*North*	*East*	*South*
		2NT	Pass
3NT			
All Pass			

3NT by East
Lead: ♠4

You have 6 HCP and a 5-card suit. Although you can't be sure, there is a good chance your hand will be useful to partner.

So you bid 3NT.

The contract would be 3NT played by West.

East plays 3NT. South leads the ♠4. You play dummy's ♠3 and North contributes the ♠6.

You can get them in ♣s, but only if you are careful.

After you unblock the ♣ A K you will go to dummy and play the ♣J. Then, after the ♣Q is driven out you will return to dummy for the two ♣ winners. That means you need **TWO** dummy entries.

Those two entries can only be the ♠K and ♠J. So you absolutely **MUST** win the first trick in your hand with the ♠A. Then play the ♣ A K. Over to dummy by playing ♠9 to ♠J. Lead the ♣J to drive out the ♣Q. Win whatever they return and play ♠Q to ♠K to reach your two good ♣s.

When you need dummy entries you may need to win a trick in your hand with an unnecessarily high card - like in this case.

You can only win 3 ♠ tricks however you play it, so you play to suit your entry needs.

Board 3
South Deals
None Vul

	♠ 7 4 ♥ K 7 5 2 ♦ 9 5 ♣ A Q 8 4 3	
♠ K 10 8 6 2 ♥ Q 10 4 ♦ J 8 4 3 ♣ 6	N W E S	♠ Q 9 3 ♥ J 9 8 ♦ Q 10 7 2 ♣ K 7 5
	♠ A J 5 ♥ A 6 3 ♦ A K 6 ♣ J 10 9 2	

West	*North*	*East*	*South*
			1NT
Pass	2♣	Pass	2♦
Pass	2NT	Pass	3NT
All Pass			

3NT by South
Lead: ♠6

With no 4-card Major suit you respond 2♦ to partner's Stayman bid. Partner now bids 2NT.

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With a full 17 points you accept partner's game invitation and bid 3NT.

South plays 3NT. West leads the ♠6 on which East plays the ♠Q.

Winner List: ♠ = 1 : ♥ = 2 : ♦ = 2 : ♣ = 1 :: Total = 6

You need 3 more tricks, obviously coming from the ♣ suit.

But the burning question right now is what do you do at trick one. Do you win or hold up?

You should assume that West holds the ♠K.

If you take the ♠A right now your ♠ J 5 will provide a second stopper if it is West who gets the lead. However, if East gets the lead he will play through your holding and you may lose 4 ♠ tricks.

If you hold up you can expect East to play another ♠ through your ♠ A J and West will then establish the suit. However, in doing so he will remove any ♠ held by East.

The answer key lies in the ♣ suit. You will be finessing through West, so East is the only defender who can get the lead in ♣s. Therefore you must hold up on ♠s until the third round.

If you win the first ♠ East will play a ♠ through your ♠ J 5 when he wins the ♣K. West will then swamp you with ♠s.

But, if you hold up your ♠A until the third round, East will have no ♠ left when he wins the ♣K.

Board 4
East Deals
Both Vul

	♠ 10 9 4 ♥ 5 ♦ Q 9 6 2 ♣ A 10 9 7 2	
♠ K J 6 5 2 ♥ Q J 10 4 3 ♦ 8 3 ♣ 4		♠ A Q 3 ♥ K 7 ♦ A J 10 4 ♣ K 8 6 5
	♠ 8 7 ♥ A 9 8 6 2 ♦ K 7 5 ♣ Q J 3	

West	*North*	*East*	*South*
		1NT	Pass
2♦	Pass	2♥	Pass
2♠	Pass	4♠	
All Pass			

4♠ by West
Lead: ♥5

When you are 5-5 in the Majors you can transfer to either suit. Most will say transfer first to ♥s when you have invitational strength. So you bid 2♦.

Partner says 2♥;

When you are 5-5 in the Majors you can transfer to either suit. Most will say transfer first to ♥s when you have invitational strength. So you bid 2♦.

Partner says 2♥;

Now you show your other 5-card Major by bidding 2♠. This one hits the spot and partner raises to 4♠.

West plays 4♠. North leads the ♥5. South takes the ♥A and returns the ♥6 which North ruffs. North then plays the ♦2.

Loser List: ♠ = 0 : ♥ = 2 : ♦ = 1 : ♣ = 1 :: Total = 4

That's an odd way to show the second ♥ loser but you get the idea. You've lost 2 tricks already and it doesn't look like you can dodge the ♣A. Soooooo, you cannot afford to lose a ♦ trick.

Take dummy's ♦A and then play ♠A, ♠K, relaxing a little when both defenders follow suit both times.

Play your three high ♥s, discarding all three ♦s from dummy. Play your ♣ toward the ♣K. North will no doubt grab his ♣A but the rest will be yours, since you can ruff your ♦ loser in dummy.

It was a little unlucky to suffer that early ♥ ruff.

But it was very very lucky that the ruffer happened to be the defender with three trumps!

That meant you could pull trumps with two pulls, leaving that one important one in dummy.

Board 5
North Deals
N-S Vul

	♠ A J 4 ♥ A K 7 ♦ 10 7 4 2 ♣ K J 3	
♠ 10 9 6 3 ♥ 9 3 ♦ K 5 ♣ 10 9 8 4 2	N W E S	♠ Q 7 5 ♥ Q J 10 8 5 2 ♦ A 3 ♣ Q 5
	♠ K 8 2 ♥ 6 4 ♦ Q J 9 8 6 ♣ A 7 6	

West	*North*	*East*	*South*
	1NT	2♥	3♦
Pass	3NT		
All Pass			

3NT by North
Lead: ♥Q

Partner's 3♦ bid shows a 5-card suit and is forcing to game. While 5♦ is possibly the best contract your double ♥ stopper should sway you to 3NT instead. This is the old "9 tricks are easier than 11" principle.

North plays 3NT. As expected, East attacks in his ♥ suit.

Winner List: ♠ = 2 : ♥ = 2 : ♦ = 0 : ♣ = 2 :: Total = 6

Even if West holds both black Queens, (not likely), you can only finesse your way to 8 tricks. Since you need 9 tricks you must establish the ♦ suit.

If East holds both the ♦A and ♦K then you are going down, because they will win the race to establish ♥s before you can establish ♦s.

But when the ♦A and ♦K are in different hands you have a good chance for success; it depends on West having no ♥ at the time he takes his ♦ winner.

So you should hold up on the first ♥ trick and win the second. If East started with 6 ♥s then West will be out. So whether he wins his ♦ trick first or second he still won't be able to continue ♥s.

After your hold up West has no ♥s. If he takes the first ♦ trick he will have to lead another suit. You will still have a ♥ stopper for when East wins **HIS** ♦ trick.

On the other hand, if East takes the first ♦ trick he can certainly drive out your last ♥ stopper. But then, when West takes **HIS** ♦ winner he will have no ♥.

Finally, if East had only a 5-card ♥ suit, good defense would beat you. But they have to be sure West wins the first ♦ trick, and they might slip up.

Board 6
East Deals
E-W Vul

♠ A 7 4
♥ K 10 4 2
♦ J 9 7 4
♣ Q J

♠ K 5
♥ J 7 5 3
♦ Q 6 2
♣ 8 5 4 2



♠ J 9 6
♥ A 8
♦ A K 10 5 3
♣ A K 6

♠ Q 10 8 3 2
♥ Q 9 6
♦ 8
♣ 10 9 7 3

West	*North*	*East*	*South*
		2NT	Pass
3♣	Pass	3♦	Pass
3NT			
All Pass			

3NT by East
Lead: ♠3

Partner's 2NT opening shows 20-21 points so you know you want to be in game. To find out which game you bid a Stayman 3♣. Partner replies 3♦.

Partner's 2NT opening shows 20-21 points so you know you want to be in game. To find out which game you bid a Stayman 3♣. Partner replies 3♦.

You don't have a 4-4 ♥ fit, so you bid 3NT.

The contract would be 3NT played by West.

East plays 3NT. South leads the ♠3. Your first problem is which ♠ to play from dummy. That is an easy problem. If you play the ♠K you might lose the first five or six tricks. If you play low you guarantee a ♠ stopper. North plays the ♠A and returns the ♠7 to dummy's ♠K. South plays the ♠2 on this trick.

Winner List: ♠ = 1 : ♥ = 1 : ♦ = 3 : ♣ = 2 :: Total = 7

You need 2 more winners, and you need to get them before you lose the lead because it appears that South can cash 3 more ♠ tricks.

That means you need all 5 ♦ tricks. The good news is that the 5 missing ♦s will split 3-2 about two-thirds of the time. The bad news is that they will be 4-1 about one-third of the time. Can you protect yourself against a 4-1 break?

Maybe and maybe not. If South has ♦ J x x x there won't be anything you can do about it. But if North has this holding then you can succeed if you play your cards right.

*Did you like that "play your cards right" quip?*First play a ♦ to your ♦K; both defenders follow. Next play a ♦ to dummy's ♦Q. South discards a ♣. You are conveniently in dummy so you play dummy's last ♦ and North's ♦ J 9 are caught in a pincer movement by your ♦ A 10 5.

It was important to play the ♦s exactly as described because dummy had only one entry left, the ♦Q.

Suppose your first ♦ play had been dummy's ♦Q. You could make your contract if you play a small ♦ and finesse the ♦10. But at that point you wouldn't know whether the ♦s were splitting evenly or not. You'd be risking defeat on a hand where everybody who played for the 3-2 split was making the contract.

By taking the **SECOND** ♦ trick with dummy's ♦Q the 4-1 split is exposed at the right time.